Sorry

NO VACANCIES

A Geography of Burlington's Housing Crisis

Known for its walkable Church Street Marketplace, vibrant college culture, and easy access to the outdoors, Burlington, Vermont, is an attractive place to live. Although small by national standards this city is the largest in the state and an economic, cultural, and artistic hub.

It also has a housing crisis, and a serious one.

According to Vermont regional planners, Burlington needs about 7,000 new homes by 2050 to stabilize the market and meet its share of statewide housing growth targets. That means building 280 homes per year for the next 25 years. *For context, Vermont as a whole has added an average of 145 homes annually over the last decade.*

A housing crisis is more than a problem of supply and demand, however. It is a tangled web of variables: chronic underbuilding, conflicting demands, and many players working in the same place. This map brings together several of the pieces that shape Burlington's unique crisis and the responses to it.



A Public Crisis in Public Space

As of 2024, Vermont's homelessness rate ranks 4th in the nation and as a predominantly rural state it struggles to maintain infrastructure to support those experiencing homelessness. Burlington, with a more robust public transit system and a higher level of access to social amenities, draws many people seeking support, particularly those without shelter.

Although the city forbids camping on public land, encampments persist, particularly downtown and in parkland along the waterfront, places regulated for commercial and recreational use. With no clear solution in sight, agitation continues to grow among locals, business owners, and tourists concerned with the very visible presence of the encampments.

Committed to Affordability

The largest Community Land Trust (CLT) in the country can be found in Burlington. The Champlain Housing Trust, like other CLTs, is a nonprofit organization that holds land "in trust" for community needs, allowing for greater access to affordable housing outside the influence of market pressures. The CHT stewards 675 shared equity homes and condominiums and over 2,600 apartments. It also operates supports for people experiencing homelessness: a motel and a shelter.

Even with all this good work, the need is greater than the Trust can meet.



Future of the New North End

Burlington needs about 7,000 new homes by 2050, and the New North End has been identified as "well-positioned" to help the City meet this need. Historically, the NNE has seen little new housing, as decades of restrictive zoning limited the neighborhood to low-density development on large lots. Residents have raised concerns, however, about affordability, displacement, increased traffic, and possible development in City parks, though the City says no park development is planned.

Burlington's "Blight Sites"

In August 2026, the City of Burlington published an online list tracking its vacant and non-compliant buildings. In an already scarce housing landscape, neglected housing stock is especially painful for local residents, particularly since property ownership is concentrated among a small number of owners. This public shaming strategy is both a response to local complaints and an attempt to bring these properties back into compliance and productive use through increased public attention and scrutiny.

The Zoning Problem

Burlington first adopted zoning in 1947, and beginning in the 1970s, successive changes tightened limits on density, lot size, and lot coverage. In 2024, the City adopted the Neighborhood Code, a significant loosening of residential rules that allows more duplexes, townhouses, and small multifamily buildings. Still, the highest-density zones remain concentrated near the urban core, where the city is already most densely built, while low-density zones cover neighborhoods like the New North End.

Students Strain the Market

The University of Vermont is the biggest academic institution in the state and holds approximetaly 20% of the property value in Burlington. Already enrolling between 13-14,000 students yearly, enrollment has seen a strong upward trajectory in recent years.

Because the University only guarantees two years of on-campus housing before releasing students into an already tight housing market, town-gown tensions have grown, including the introduction of Bill H.170, which would cap UVM's enrollment until the vacancy rate improves. The University is actively working to increase housing, but like other developers in the state, has run into high construction costs, workforce shortages, and strict land use regulations.

- Large-scale Residential Development (Under Construction)
- Large-scale Residential Development (Built)
- Non-Compliant Vacant Sites
- Town Boundary
- Density of Encampment Sightings as reported on SeeClickFix
- High Intensity Residential Zoning
- Parcels owned by the Champlain Housing Trust
- Parcels owned by the University of Vermont

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